you should be able to validate certain assumptions, and you may prove others wrong. Based on this feedback, you'll be able to update your impact map and your short-term plans accordingly.

> **EXERCISE 3.5** Flying High Airlines partners with the major credit card providers. They issue credit cards that members can use to accumulate Frequent Flyer points when they make ordinary day-to-day purchases. Flying High Airlines receives commissions when Frequent Flyer members purchase goods this way. Identify the underlying business goal behind this strategy, and draw up an impact map to discover how the Frequent Flyer website might contribute to this goal.

Impact Mapping is a simple and convenient approach to building up an initial picture of what you're trying to achieve in a project. Impact maps are visual and intuitive, fast to draw, and accessible for both business people and technical folk.

Impact maps can also be used quite effectively in the other direction, though for a slightly different purpose. Suppose, for example, that you already have a set of proposed features: a product backlog in an Agile project, a set of use cases, or even a set of high-level requirements in a more traditional requirements-specification document. Suppose, while you're at it, that the requested features come from different stakeholders, who are each convinced that "their" feature should be done first.

In this case, impact maps make a great conversation starter. I've found the following strategy effective: get your stakeholders together, put the requested features on a whiteboard, and identify who they'll benefit and how they'll benefit them, working back to the underlying business goals. Eventually you'll end up with a graph that shows a number of goals, with a relatively clear illustration of which features map to which goals. This visual representation of all of the goals and the supporting features is an excellent starting point for a discussion of the relative merit of each goal, and of each feature, and makes it much easier to prioritize the different features more objectively.

If you're interested in learning more about Impact Mapping, take a look at the Impact Mapping website (http://impactmapping.org) and read the book *Impact Mapping* by Gojko Adzic.

3.6 Who will benefit? Identify stakeholders and their needs

As you've seen, all projects ultimately aim to benefit the organization in some way. But organizations are made up of people, and it will be people within this organization (or people who interact with this organization) who will be affected by the outcomes of your project. These people are the *stakeholders* or *actors*. The impact maps we looked at earlier emphasize the importance of stakeholders in identifying valuable features. Let's look at this in more detail.

Note that even when the overall effect of a project is designed to be beneficial for the organization, the impact of the project on an individual basis may be negative. For